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Chapter 1 — The Key

The landlord's office is on the ground floor of the building. Sign the paper on the counter: name, date, address of the apartment. The landlord says the apartment must be empty by the end of the month and the key returned to this office. The landlord puts the key on the counter and slides it across. Take the key. Thank the landlord and leave.

Climb the stairs to the third floor. The landings have brown tile, worn in the middle. A potted plant stands outside a neighbour's door on the second floor. At the top of the third-floor landing, put the key in the lock and turn it. The lock turns without resistance. Open the door and go in.

The apartment is quiet. The hallway runs the length of it, doors to left and right. The smell is the smell of an apartment that has not been opened for a few days. Underneath is the smell of old wool and soap.

Walk through the rooms.

The kitchen is on the right at the end of the hall. The window above the sink faces the elm. The counter is clean. The coffee machine sits on the counter to the left of the sink, the cups in the cupboard above it, a jar of pens beside the sink. The phone is on the wall beside the door to the hall. Under the window opposite the counter stands a small round table with two chairs. The surface of the table is marked with two pale rings where hot pans have been set down and left for years.

The living room is at the far end of the hall, past the kitchen door. The bookshelves run along the long wall, full. Against the window wall sits a sofa with a coffee table in front of it, a lamp beside the sofa. The rug on the floor is frayed at the edges and has lost its colour at the centre where the path from the sofa to the door has worn a track. The television is not on.

The bedroom is off the hallway to the left. The wardrobe stands against the back wall, closed. The bed is made: a white cover, two pillows. Beside the bed stands a bedside table with a lamp and a book on it. The book is a paperback, the spine creased, a slip of paper at about a third of the way through. The slip is a torn corner of newspaper. The dressing table is by the window, a small bottle of perfume on it.

The second room is next to the bedroom. Boxes are stacked along one wall, a folded camp bed in the corner, three cardboard boxes on the floor, taped shut, unlabelled. A window at the back looks onto the inner courtyard.

The bathroom is off the hallway on the right. White tiles cover the walls to half-height. Above the sink hangs a mirror beside a small window. The silvering of the mirror is spotted at the edges and clouded where the hot water has risen against it for years. On the shelf below stand a toothbrush in a glass and a bar of soap dried on a dish.

The balcony is off the living room through a glass door. Two dead plants in terracotta pots stand by the wall. A wooden chair is by the railing. The chair is old and weathered, the slats of the seat split where the wood has dried over the years.

Walk back through the hallway to the kitchen.

Fill the kettle from the tap and put it on the hob. Turn the dial for the front burner and the flame catches. Take a cup down from the cupboard above the coffee machine. The cup is one of mother's, white, thick at

the rim, a chip on the underside of the handle. Take the jar of coffee from the cupboard beside the fridge and spoon two spoonfuls into the cup. The kettle ticks and then clicks off. Turn off the flame. Pour the water and stir with a spoon from the drawer under the counter.

Drink the coffee at the counter.

The elm is at the window. The light from the window falls across the counter in a rectangle that reaches almost to the sink. A cyclist passes on the street below, then a woman with a shopping bag the other way, then a man with a dog. The rectangle of light moves as the clouds shift and then holds. The elm's higher branches make small shadows across the rectangle. The cup is warm in a hand.

Finish the coffee. Rinse the cup under the tap and put it back in the cupboard above the coffee machine.

Take paper from the drawer of the kitchen table and a pen from the jar on the counter. Sit down at the kitchen table and write the list:

1. Kitchen — pack and clean
2. Cancel utilities
3. The bedroom — clothes to charity
4. Find the will
5. Living room — books
6. Sort photographs
7. Cancel phone line
8. Death certificate — copies
9. Bank — close account
10. Balcony — clear
11. Second room — clear
12. Return library book
13. Final clean
14. Return key

Read the list once. Set the pen on the paper. Pick it up and put it back in the jar. Fold the paper once and then once again and put it in the inside pocket of the coat on the back of the chair. Put the coat on and walk to the door.

The phone on the kitchen wall is black, the kind with a cord, the cord coiled once around the hook below the handset, the handset on its cradle where mother left it.

Open the front door, step out, and turn the key in the lock. Drop the key into the right pocket of the coat. Walk down the stairs, past the second-floor landing with its potted plant, and out through the front door of the building.

The street is empty.

Chapter 2 — The Boxes

The hardware shop is on the corner of the street two blocks from the apartment. A bell rings at the door on the way in. The boxes are stacked along the back wall, flat-packed in bundles of ten. Take two bundles of ten and carry them to the counter. Pick up a tape gun, three rolls of tape, a black marker, a stack of newspaper folded into quarters and tied with string. Pay at the counter. The shopkeeper puts the small things in a paper bag and leaves the boxes on the counter to be carried by hand.

Carry the boxes under one arm and the bag of supplies in the other hand. Walk the two blocks back to the building. The street is quiet. The bakery on the corner is open.

Unlock the front door of the building and climb the stairs to the third floor. At the top of the third-floor landing, put the boxes down, take the key from the right pocket of the coat, unlock the apartment door, and carry everything in. Drop the key back into the pocket. Hang the coat on the hook by the door.

Carry the boxes to the kitchen. Put the bundles on the floor beside the cupboard above the coffee machine. Cut the string on the first bundle with a knife from the drawer under the counter.

Assemble a box. Fold the sides up, tuck the flaps at the bottom, run a strip of tape along the seam. The box stands on the floor by the counter. Assemble another.

The plates are in the cupboard above the coffee machine. Take them down in stacks of four and set them on the counter.

Tear a sheet of newspaper from the stack on the kitchen table and lay it flat. Place the plate in the middle, bring the corners of the paper up and over, and press them around the edge of the plate with the side of a thumb. Pick up the tape, pull an inch, cut it on the dispenser's blade, and press the tape across the seam.

Put the wrapped plate in the box at the feet. Take another sheet of newspaper.

At twelve plates, fold the flaps of the newspaper over the top layer, close the box, run a strip of tape along the seam, and write KITCHEN on the side with the marker from the counter.

Assemble the next box.

The glasses are in the cupboard beside the plates. Take four down and set them on the counter. Reach for the tape on the counter.

Stop.

The fridge hums under the counter to the right of the sink. The door is heavy on its hinges and gives slightly when it opens. Inside: a carton of milk, two tomatoes, a half-wrapped block of cheese, a jar of pickles, half a bottle of tonic water, three eggs in the door shelf, a dish of something covered with foil, a bunch of parsley wilted in a glass of water, a pot of yoghurt with the lid peeled back and resealed. On the top shelf, a lemon with a bite out of it, the bite dried at the edges.

Shake the milk. The carton slops thickly.

Take a roll of bin bags from under the sink. Open one bag and hold it open on the floor beside the fridge. Start with the top shelf. Take out the carton of milk and put it in the bag. Take out the tomatoes, the

cheese, the jar of pickles (twist the lid, empty the pickles into the bag, drop the jar in with them), the tonic water, the eggs, the dish under foil, the parsley in the glass, the lemon, the yoghurt, the things in the door.

The bag is heavy at the bottom.

Tie the bag. Start another bag and empty the second shelf and the drawers at the bottom. Carry the bags down the stairs, past the second-floor landing with the potted plant, out through the front door of the building, to the bins behind the building.

The bins are green and full. Push the bags down into the top of the rubbish bin and close the lid.

Back up the stairs.

The fridge interior is sticky. Wet a cloth at the sink and wipe down the shelves, the door, the drawers. Rinse the cloth in the sink twice. Leave the fridge door open a crack.

Rinse the cloth a last time and hang it over the tap. The light through the kitchen window has moved. The rectangle of light on the counter has shortened and now falls only on the edge nearest the wall. Stand at the counter and watch the edge hold.

The box of wrapped plates stands on the floor. The glasses are on the counter, unwrapped. The tape dispenser is on the table.

Take the list from the inside pocket of the coat on the hook by the door. Cross off the first half of Item 1 with the pen from the jar on the counter: *Kitchen* — *pack* is now crossed off, *and clean* is not. Underneath Item 1 in smaller letters add a new sub-item: *glasses (tomorrow)*. Fold the paper once and then once again and put it back in the inside pocket of the coat.

Put the coat on. Take the key from the right pocket. Pull the apartment door closed and turn the key in the lock. Drop the key back into the pocket.

Walk down the stairs, past the second-floor landing with its potted plant, and out through the front door of the building.

The street is empty.

Chapter 3 — The Utility Company

Unlock the apartment door with the key from the right pocket of the coat and go in. The hallway runs the length of it, doors to left and right. The air of the apartment is still, slightly cooler than the stairwell, carrying the smell of the place by now so familiar that it no longer registers. Drop the key back into the pocket. Hang the coat on the hook by the door.

Walk into the kitchen. The counter is clean. The phone is on the wall beside the door to the hall. Take the mobile from the inside pocket of the coat on the hook and carry it to the counter. The mobile is cool in the hand. Dial the number of the utility company from the top of the last bill.

The line rings and then a recorded voice asks for the account number. Press 1 for English. Press 2 to speak to an operator. Hold.

The hold music is a single piece of light piano, looping. Stand at the counter and look out at the elm through the kitchen window while the music loops. The elm is in leaf. The light from the window falls across the counter in a rectangle that reaches almost to the sink, and across the rectangle the shadow of the elm's higher branches moves as the branches move in a wind. Watch the shadow move for the length of one loop of the music. Watch the shadow move for the length of another. Shift the mobile to the other ear. A woman walks a small dog along the street below. After four loops, an operator picks up.

The operator asks for the account number.

The account number is not on the mobile. It is on a bill. The bills are in a folder in the apartment.

Put the mobile face down on the counter. The operator waits on the line. Walk through the hallway to find the folder.

Walk through the kitchen to the bedroom. The folder is on top of the dressing table by the window, leaning against the small bottle of perfume, where it is kept. Take the folder and the bill at the front of it back to the kitchen counter.

Lift the mobile. The account number is at the top of the bill. The operator hears the digits one at a time and types each one in turn. The operator reads the number back. Confirm.

The operator asks for the name on the account.

The name is at the top of the bill. The operator hears it and types. The middle initial is a P.

The operator says the name on the account has a slightly different initial and asks whether this is the right account.

Confirm.

The operator says the notice of death has been received. The mobile is warm against the ear. The operator says the final bill has been calculated and will be sent to the forwarding address on file. The operator asks whether the forwarding address is still correct.

Look at the bill. The forwarding address is the apartment. Confirm.

The operator says the account will be closed at the end of the month and wishes a good day. Thank the operator. End the call.

Put the mobile back in the inside pocket of the coat on the hook. Fill a glass at the tap and drink it at the counter. The water is cold and tastes of the pipes of this building. Rinse the glass and set it upside down on the draining board.

Take the folder to the small round table under the kitchen window. Sit down in the chair closer to the window. The cushion on the seat is slightly indented in the middle. Open the folder on the table.

The folder contains utility bills in plastic sleeves, six months of them, the name with the extra initial on every one. The plastic sleeves are labelled with coloured tabs on the right edge, a different colour for each kind of bill: yellow for electricity, blue for water, green for the telephone. Behind the bills, loose, a handwritten note listing the dates of three dentist appointments. At the back of the folder, a library notice saying a book is overdue. The title is not one that stops the hand.

Close the folder and put it back on the dressing table. Take the library notice off the folder and set it on the counter beside the door to the hall.

Walk back through the kitchen to the hallway and check the small table by the front door where things are sometimes left. The library book is on the table, a hardback with a paper jacket, a bookmark peeking out near the end. Put the book on the floor next to the door with the library notice on top of it.

The list is in the inside pocket of the coat on the hook. Take it out and read it at the counter. The paper is creased sharply at the folds. Item 2 — *Cancel utilities* — has a line drawn through it. The line is in the same pen and the same hand as the rest of the list. No hand drew the line at the table. Read the list to the end. Fold the paper once and then once again and put it back in the inside pocket of the coat.

Put the coat on. Pick up the library book from the floor, the library notice folded on top of it. The book is heavy in the hand. Take the key from the right pocket of the coat. Pull the apartment door closed and turn the key in the lock. Drop the key back into the pocket.

Walk down the stairs, past the second-floor landing with its potted plant, and out through the front door of the building.

The library is four blocks from the apartment, past the bakery on the corner, across the crossing with the traffic light, and along the street with the lime trees. The bakery window is full of loaves in rows. The crossing light is red, then green. The lime trees are in leaf along the length of the street, the leaves young and pale at the new growth. Past the corner with the pharmacy on the left, over the grating where the pavement dips, past the bicycle chained to the railing outside the tobacconist, to the library steps.

The library is quiet and warm, the smell of old paper and floor polish. Two people read at tables by the window, one of them a boy in a school uniform. The librarian at the returns desk is older, a woman, with glasses on a chain around her neck. The glasses have a gold rim, thinned to copper at the bridge where years of setting them down have worn the metal.

Put the book and the notice on the desk. The librarian picks up the book and scans the barcode. The scanner beeps once. The librarian looks at the date on the screen and then at the face above the desk and then back at the screen.

The librarian says the fine is waived for today. The librarian takes a rubber stamp from a tin on the desk and stamps the notice with *RETURNED*, the red ink fresh on the paper, and hands it back.

Thank the librarian.

Walk back through the library to the door, past the two readers. The boy in the school uniform is turning a page of his book. Through the door, pull it closed, down the library steps, out onto the street, the weight of the book and the notice gone from one arm.

The street is empty.

Chapter 4 — The Clothes

Unlock the apartment door with the key from the right pocket of the coat and go in. The hallway runs the length of it, doors to left and right. Drop the key back into the pocket. Hang the coat on the hook by the door.

Walk through the hallway to the bedroom.

The wardrobe stands against the back wall. Open both doors. The hanging clothes are on the rail: coats, dresses, blouses, a few skirts. Folded clothes are on the shelves above and below: sweaters, a row of folded trousers, a stack of cardigans, a tray of smaller things. Two pairs of shoes are on the floor of the wardrobe.

Bring a black bin bag in from the kitchen and hang it over the open wardrobe door.

Take the hanging clothes off the rail one at a time. Slide each one off its hanger, fold it in half and then in half again, and put it in the bin bag. The coats are heavier and take two folds. The dresses fold smaller. The fabric is soft. The cardigan at the end of the rail has the sleeves worn thin at the cuffs.

When the rail is empty, leave the hangers on the rail.

Take the folded clothes off the shelves. Put them in the bin bag without unfolding. The bag fills. Tie the top of the bag. Bring another bag from the kitchen and hang it over the door.

Continue with the second shelf. Finish the shelves. Finish the tray of smaller things. The second bag fills. Tie the top.

The shoes on the floor of the wardrobe. Two pairs: a pair of brown leather shoes and a pair of slippers. The brown shoes are shaped to the feet that wore them. Put both pairs in a third bag.

Three bags by the open wardrobe. The shelves are bare.

Walk through the hallway to the kitchen drawer under the counter. Open the drawer to find scissors to cut the tags off the bags before delivery. The drawer has the scissors, a ball of kitchen twine, a roll of masking tape, a small notebook, a fold-down pair of reading glasses, two pens, a box of matches, a packet of seeds, and a folded piece of paper.

The folded piece of paper is a grocery list in mother's handwriting. *Milk, bread, fish, oranges*. The handwriting is careful and slightly slanted. The paper is thin where the pen has pressed the letters.

Stand at the drawer with the list in a hand.

Read the grocery list once and put it back in the drawer.

Take the scissors out of the drawer and close it.

Back to the bedroom. Cut the tags off the three bags. Tie the tops of the bags in simple knots. Carry the first two bags to the hall by the front door. Come back for the third.

Take the mobile from the inside pocket of the coat on the hook and call a charity shop. The first charity shop says they need the clothes on hangers to accept them; bags will not do. End the call. Call a second charity shop. The second charity shop says the clothes need to be washed before they are brought in. End the call.

Put the mobile back in the inside pocket of the coat.

Untie the first bag. Take the clothes out one at a time and sort them into a pile by the washing machine in the bathroom. The washing machine is small, will take one bag's worth at a time. Load the first batch into the washing machine. Measure powder. Close the door. Turn the dial to the usual setting without looking. Press the button.

The washing machine starts.

Sit in the kitchen at the small round table under the window and wait. The elm is at the window. The light from the window falls across the counter in a rectangle that reaches almost to the sink. The rectangle moves as the clouds shift and then holds.

The washing machine cycles through its programme. The sound of water. The sound of the drum turning.

At the end of the cycle, take the clothes out and carry them to the balcony to dry. Through the living room to the glass door of the balcony. Unlatch the door and step out.

A drying rack stands folded behind the wooden chair by the railing. Unfold the drying rack and stand it in the middle of the balcony. Hang the wet clothes on it one at a time: the dresses first, then the blouses, then the cardigans. The clothes are heavy and cold where the water has soaked through. Leave the heavier things for the next batch.

Back to the bathroom. Load the second batch into the washing machine. Start the machine. Sit in the kitchen at the small round table under the window and wait.

At the end of the second cycle, carry the wet clothes to the balcony and hang them on the rack.

The third batch.

The light through the kitchen window has moved further. The rectangle is gone and the counter is in shadow. The elm is darker against the darkening sky.

At the end of the third cycle, the rack on the balcony is full of clothes and the balcony air is cool. Leave them to dry overnight.

Take the list from the inside pocket of the coat at the kitchen counter. Read it. Cross off part of Item 3 — *The bedroom — clothes* — and leave the *to charity* part uncrossed. Fold the paper once and then once again and put it back in the inside pocket of the coat.

Walk through the hallway to the bedroom. The wardrobe doors stand open. The rail is empty. The shelves are bare.

Walk back through the hallway to the front door.

The three bags are stacked by the front door.

Put the coat on from the hook. Take the key from the right pocket of the coat. Pull the apartment door closed and turn the key in the lock. Drop the key back into the pocket.

Walk down the stairs, past the second-floor landing with its potted plant, and out through the front door of the building.

The street is empty.

Chapter 5 — The Will

Unlock the apartment door with the key from the right pocket of the coat and go in. The hallway runs the length of it, doors to left and right. Drop the key back into the pocket. Hang the coat on the hook by the door.

Take the mobile from the inside pocket of the coat and call the lawyer. The lawyer's secretary answers and asks to hold. Stand at the kitchen counter and look out at the elm while the line holds. The lawyer picks up after a minute.

The lawyer asks about mother's estate. The lawyer says the will should be in the apartment. The lawyer says that when a copy is found, to bring it to the office or send a photograph of the signed last page by email. Thank the lawyer. End the call.

Put the mobile on the counter.

The will is in a metal box on top of the wardrobe.

Walk through the hallway to the bedroom. Stand in front of the wardrobe. Reach up with both hands to the top of the wardrobe. The top is flat and dusty.

Run a hand across the top to be sure. The dust is undisturbed.

Bring the kitchen chair through the hallway to the bedroom and stand on it to see the top of the wardrobe at eye level. At the back of the top, the dust is lighter where the box has stood for years.

Step down off the chair.

Open the wardrobe. The wardrobe is empty. The hangers are gone from the rail. The shelves are bare. The two pairs of shoes are gone. A faint smell of the clothes remains.

Walk through the bedroom to the second room.

The second room has a desk in it.

The desk stands against the back wall under the window that looks onto the inner courtyard. The desk is old wood, dark, with a drawer in the middle and two smaller drawers on the right. The chair behind the desk is the same wood.

The boxes stacked along the wall are still there. The folded camp bed is still in the corner. The three cardboard boxes on the floor, taped shut, unlabelled, are still in place.

Open the drawer in the middle of the desk. The drawer slides out smoothly. Inside: a pencil, a blank notebook with a hard cover, a paperclip, a rubber band. No will.

Open the top drawer on the right. Empty.

Open the second drawer on the right. Empty.

Close the drawers.

Walk back through the bedroom to the hallway to the kitchen to the mobile on the counter. Call the lawyer again. The lawyer's secretary says the lawyer has left for the afternoon and will be back tomorrow morning. Leave a message saying the will is not in the usual place. End the call.

Put the mobile on the counter.

Call the utility company from the mobile for a follow-up on the account number discrepancy. The hold music is the same piece of light piano. After three loops the operator picks up. The operator says the matter is still being looked into and that a note will be left on the account.

Thank the operator. End the call.

Put the mobile on the counter.

Walk back through the hallway to the bedroom to the wardrobe.

The wardrobe is full.

The rail is full of hanging clothes: the coats, the dresses, the blouses, the cardigans. The cardigan at the end of the rail still has the sleeves worn thin at the cuffs. The shelves above are full of folded sweaters and trousers. The two pairs of shoes are on the floor of the wardrobe.

Stand in front of the wardrobe for a minute.

Start folding. Take the hanging clothes off the rail one at a time. Fold each in half and then in half again. The fabric is soft. The cardigan at the end of the rail has the sleeves worn thin at the cuffs.

Stop.

Take the list from the inside pocket of the coat at the wardrobe. Read it at the rail. Item 2 still has the line through it that no hand drew at the table. Item 3 has the half-cross from the clothes. Below Item 14, a new entry in the same handwriting: *15. Sort desk*. Read the list to the end. Fold the paper once and then once again and put it back in the inside pocket of the coat.

Close the wardrobe. The hangers behind the door click softly.

Walk through the hallway to the front door. Put the coat on from the hook. Take the key from the right pocket. Pull the apartment door closed and turn the key in the lock. Drop the key back into the pocket.

Walk down the stairs, past the second-floor landing with its potted plant, and out through the front door of the building.

The street is empty.

Chapter 6 — The Photographs

Unlock the apartment door with the key from the right pocket of the coat and go in. The hallway runs the length of it, doors to left and right. Drop the key back into the pocket. Hang the coat on the hook by the door.

Walk through the hallway to the living room. The bookshelves run along the long wall, full. On the second shelf from the top, between two hardbacks, a shoebox. The shoebox is old, the cardboard soft at the corners, the lid slightly bent.

Take the shoebox down and carry it to the rug in the middle of the room. Sit down on the rug with the shoebox between the legs. Lift off the lid.

The shoebox is full of photographs. Colour, some older and fading at the edges, some newer. A few black-and-whites from the back of the box. None of them in albums, none of them labelled except for a few with a date on the back in mother's handwriting.

Take the photographs out one at a time and lay them on the rug.

Mother, young, standing in front of a building that is not this building. Mother, older, by the window of this kitchen, the elm visible behind her. A holiday photograph: mountains, two women leaning against a railing, the railing on a viewpoint looking down into a valley. A birthday: a cake on a table, candles lit, the flash of the camera making the icing too white. A garden with long grass and a line of fruit trees, a house behind. Mother at the garden, younger than the kitchen photograph.

A photograph of a child of about six, in a striped shirt, holding a wooden horse on a string.

Keep going.

A photograph of a summer afternoon outside a house with a red door. Two adults and a child on the step. The adults are mother and a man. The man has a moustache and holds the child's hand. The child is the same as the child in the striped shirt.

Keep going.

A photograph of a man at a desk, writing, the back of his head. A photograph of a beach with two people in the distance. A photograph of the inside of a car. A photograph of a birthday cake on the same kitchen table as the cake photograph above but with different candles. A photograph of a Christmas tree. A photograph of a row of people at a long table, eating, no face clearly in focus. A photograph of the child in the striped shirt, older, leaning against a bicycle. A photograph of mother and a woman with grey hair at a café, mother looking at the camera and the other woman looking away.

Keep going.

The stack on the left of the rug grows. The stack on the right of the rug stays empty.

When the shoebox is empty, sit back on the heels and look at the stack.

Put the photographs back in the shoebox in the order they came out. Put the lid back on.

Carry the shoebox to the living room shelf and put it back between the two hardbacks on the second shelf from the top.

Walk through the hallway to the bedroom. The wardrobe is closed. The bed is made. The bedside drawer. Open the bedside drawer on the near side of the bed.

The drawer contains a tube of hand cream, a reading lamp bulb in a small box, a paperback novel with the place held by a train ticket, a strip of paracetamol, and a single photograph loose at the back of the drawer.

Take the loose photograph out.

The photograph is mother and a child. The child is about eight. Mother sits on a low wall with an arm around the child's shoulders. The child is the child in the striped shirt, older. Mother is smiling. The background is a garden with long grass.

Put the photograph in the inside pocket of the coat on the hook by the door.

Back to the kitchen.

Make coffee. Fill the kettle and put it on. Reach up to the cupboard above the coffee machine.

The cupboard is empty.

Open the cupboard to the left of the coffee machine, the one with the plates, without looking. The cups are in the cupboard with the plates. Take one down. The cup is one of mother's, white, thick at the rim, a chip on the underside of the handle.

Spoon coffee into the cup. Pour the water. Stir.

Drink the coffee at the counter.

The elm is at the window. The light from the window falls across the counter in a rectangle that reaches almost to the sink. The rectangle moves as the clouds shift and then holds.

Put the cup down on the counter.

Walk to the phone on the wall beside the door to the hall. Pick up the receiver. Hold it to an ear. A dial tone, steady. Put the receiver back on the cradle.

Back to the coffee at the counter.

Finish the coffee. Rinse the cup under the tap and put it back in the cupboard with the plates.

Walk through the hallway to the living room. Take the shoebox down from the shelf again and sit on the rug with it between the legs. Lift off the lid.

The photographs are in the shoebox. The photograph of mother and the child on the low wall is on top of the stack, loose, face up. Three people are in the photograph: mother on the low wall, the child beside her, and a woman standing behind them in the grass, her face out of focus.

Put the lid back on the shoebox and put the shoebox back on the shelf between the two hardbacks.

Take the list from the inside pocket of the coat at the kitchen counter. Read it. Below Item 6 — *Sort photographs* — a new line in a handwriting that is the same but slightly looser: *call Marianne*. Read the list to the end. Fold the paper once and then once again and put it back in the inside pocket of the coat.

Put the coat on. Take the key from the right pocket. Pull the apartment door closed and turn the key in the lock. Drop the key back into the pocket.

Walk down the stairs, past the second-floor landing with its potted plant, and out through the front door of the building.

The street is empty.

Chapter 7 — The Neighbour

Morning.

The rain is against the window of the kitchen. The kitchen of the apartment that is not mother's apartment. The counter is clean. The coffee machine sits on the counter to the left of the sink. The cups are in the cupboard above the coffee machine.

The list is in the coat on the hook in the hall.

Fill the kettle from the tap and put it on the hob. Take a cup down from the cupboard. The cup is not mother's cup. The cup is thicker, a darker shape, a band of blue around the rim. Spoon coffee into the cup. The kettle ticks and then clicks off. Pour the water and stir with a spoon from the drawer.

Drink the coffee at the window.

The street below is wet. A car passes, then another. The sign of the bakery on the corner is red and says BAKERY in white letters. A woman with an umbrella crosses at the corner. The rain is steady. The opposite building has six windows on the second floor of its grey facade.

Finish the coffee. Rinse the cup under the tap and put it back in the cupboard.

Take a plate from the rack beside the sink and put breakfast on it: bread, butter, two slices of cheese. Eat at the small table by the window. Turn the pages of the newspaper while eating. The news is the news. The rain continues against the window.

Finish the breakfast. Wash the plate and the knife and put them in the rack.

Stand at the window for a while. The rain slows. The cars pass. A dog on the pavement across the street waits by a doorway and then goes in when the door opens.

In the middle of the day, take the plates from the cupboard. Six plates, thicker than mother's plates, a band of blue around the rims. Set them on the counter beside the sink.

A stack of newspaper is on the chair by the table. Tear a sheet from the top of the stack and lay it flat on the counter. Place a plate in the middle of the sheet, bring the corners of the paper up and over, and press them around the edge of the plate with the side of a thumb. Pick up the tape from the counter and pull an inch. Cut it on the dispenser's blade. Press the tape across the seam.

Put the wrapped plate in the box at the feet.

Wrap the second plate. The corners of the paper up and over and pressed around the edge with the side of a thumb. Tape. In the box.

Wrap the third plate. Tape. In the box.

Stop.

Fill the kettle from the tap and put it on the hob. Take a cup down from the cupboard. Spoon coffee into the cup. Pour the water. Stir.

Drink the coffee at the window.

The rain has stopped. The cars pass. A woman with two bags of groceries crosses the street. Three boys on bicycles. The light on the opposite building moves as a cloud moves.

Count the windows on the second floor of the opposite building. Five. Count again. Five.

Finish the coffee. Put the cup in the sink.

The box of plates is on the counter, half full. Three plates wrapped in newspaper, taped. The other three plates are still on the counter beside the box. The newspaper is on the chair. The tape dispenser is on the counter.

Walk to the living room and stand at the window that looks onto the back of the building. The courtyard is below. Three bicycles are chained to a rail.

Back to the kitchen.

The doorbell of the apartment rings.

Walk to the door of the apartment and open it. A neighbour from downstairs is on the landing. The neighbour is older, a woman, wearing a cardigan over a blouse. The neighbour has never been at this door before.

The neighbour asks if all is well. The neighbour says that movement has been heard at night from this flat, by the neighbour on the floor below and by the flat above, and that the neighbours are asking after it.

The hand on the edge of the door is still.

Confirm that all is well and that sleep is fine.

The neighbour looks past the door and into the hall of the apartment and then back.

The neighbour says to come knock at the door of flat four, directly below, if anything is needed at any time. The neighbour nods.

Thank the neighbour.

The neighbour turns and goes back down the stairs. The sound of the footsteps on the stairs. The sound of a door on the floor below being opened and then closed.

Close the door of the apartment.

Walk back to the kitchen.

The box on the counter is half full. The newspaper is on the chair. The tape dispenser is on the counter. The three wrapped plates are in the box. The three unwrapped plates are on the counter beside the box.

Walk to the window of the kitchen and stand at it.

The bakery sign on the corner is red and says BAKERY. The rain has started again. A car passes.

Stand at the window for a long time.

Eat something from the fridge in the evening: bread, cheese, a tomato. Wash the things and put them in the rack.

The box of plates is on the counter.

Turn off the lamps in the living room, then the hallway lamp, then the kitchen light.

Go to the bedroom. Undress. Bed.

Dark.

Chapter 8 — The Death Certificate

The civil registry office is on the ground floor of a building three streets away from the apartment, past the bakery, across the crossing, along the street with the lime trees, past the library, left at the corner with the pharmacy, and down to the end of the street.

Take a number from the machine inside the door and sit on the bench in the waiting area. The bench is wood with a worn varnish. Four other people are in the waiting area, each with a number.

When the number is called, go to the window at the far end. The clerk hands a form across the counter on a clipboard with a biro tied to it by a string.

Sit back down on the bench with the clipboard and fill out the form at the small writing counter attached to the bench.

Name of the deceased. Date of birth. Place of birth. Mother's full name. Father's full name. Date of death. Place of death. Cause of death. Relationship of the person filling out the form. Signature. Date.

The biro is tied to the clipboard by a string. At the right edge of the signature line, the string pulls. Each line filled without pause. The pen does not stop.

Carry the clipboard back to the window. The clerk takes the clipboard, reads the form, types at a keyboard, prints a sheet, stamps the sheet, and slides it across the counter. Three extra copies are needed. The clerk hears this and prints three more sheets, stamps each, and slides them across.

Pay the fee in cash from the inside pocket of the coat. Thank the clerk. Fold the four sheets together and put them in the inside pocket of the coat with the list.

Walk out of the civil registry office and back along the street. Past the pharmacy, right at the corner, past the library, along the street with the lime trees, across the crossing, past the bakery, to the building.

Unlock the front door of the building and climb the stairs to the third floor. At the top of the third-floor landing, put the key from the right pocket of the coat in the apartment door and turn it. Open the door and go in. Drop the key back into the pocket. Hang the coat on the hook by the door.

Take the four sheets out of the inside pocket of the coat and put them on the small round table in the kitchen, under a glass to keep them flat.

Walk through the hallway to the living room.

The bookshelves run along the long wall, full.

The bookshelves are full.

Assemble two boxes from the stack in the hall. Put them on the floor in front of the bookshelves. Take the tape gun from the kitchen counter. Take the newspaper from the pile on the kitchen table.

Take the books down four at a time. Wrap them in sheets of newspaper. Put them in the box in the order they come off the shelf. At twelve books, fold the newspaper over, close the box, run a strip of tape along the seam, and label it with the marker.

Start on the second shelf. Take the books down four at a time. A hand stops on a hardback. The cover is dark cloth, no dust jacket. Open the book at the front. The page before the title page is blank.

Close the book. Wrap it in a sheet of newspaper. Put it in the box with the others. Take down the next four books.

Finish the second shelf. Assemble the next box. Start on the third shelf.

The phone on the kitchen wall rings.

Stop. Stand with a book in hand. The phone rings again. The phone does not stop. The book stays in the hand. Do not walk to the phone.

Continue wrapping. Place the book in the box. Take down the next four books. Wrap them.

The ringing continues.

Continue wrapping.

The ringing stops.

Continue to the end of the third shelf. Close the box. Tape it. Label it.

At the end of the afternoon, four boxes stand by the front door.

Take the list from the inside pocket of the coat at the kitchen counter. Item 5 — *Living room — books* — has a line through it. The line is in the same pen as the rest of the list. Draw a small question mark next to it with the pen from the jar on the counter. Look at the rest of the list. The top items are in a looser handwriting than the items below. Fold the paper once and then once again and put it back in the inside pocket of the coat.

Put the four sheets of the death certificate under the glass into the inside pocket of the coat with the list.

Put the coat on from the hook. Take the key from the right pocket. Pull the apartment door closed and turn the key in the lock. Drop the key back into the pocket.

Walk down the stairs, past the second-floor landing with its potted plant, and out through the front door of the building.

The street is empty.

Chapter 9 — The Bank

The bank is six streets from the apartment, in the direction of the centre of the city. Walk to the bank with the death certificate and the birth certificate folded together in the inside pocket of the coat. Take a number at the door. Sit on the row of chairs along the wall.

The bank is quiet. Two customers at the windows, two tellers. The number is called.

Go to the window.

The teller is young, a man in a blue shirt. The account of mother is to be closed. The teller hears this and nods.

The teller types at the keyboard and asks for the name and account number. Read the name and account number off the bank statement taken from the inside pocket of the coat with the other documents.

The teller types and reads the screen. The teller says that the bank has been notified of the death and that the account has been flagged pending closure. The teller says that to proceed, the bank requires three things: the death certificate, the will or a letter of authority from the solicitor handling the estate, and proof that the person at the window is the next of kin.

Put the death certificate on the counter. The teller takes it, looks at it, photocopies it at the machine behind the counter, and hands the original back.

The will is not here. The will is with the solicitor.

Put the birth certificate on the counter. The teller takes it and looks at it. The teller reads the name of the mother on the birth certificate and the name of the mother on the death certificate and then the name on the bank statement.

The teller says that the middle name of mother is different on the birth certificate and on the death certificate.

Look at the two documents on the counter. Mother's name on the birth certificate has a middle name that begins with E. Mother's name on the death certificate has a middle name that begins with I.

The teller waits.

The discrepancy is a typing error at the registry office. A corrected death certificate can be obtained. The teller hears this and waits.

The teller says to come back with the corrected death certificate and with a letter from the solicitor confirming the estate. The teller slides the birth certificate back across the counter.

Thank the teller. Put the documents back into the inside pocket of the coat.

Walk out of the bank and along the pavement until there is a bench in the sun. Sit on the bench and take the mobile from the inside pocket of the coat. Call the solicitor.

The solicitor's secretary answers and puts the line through. The solicitor asks how the meeting at the bank went.

The middle name is different on the two documents. The letter of authority has not yet been sent. The solicitor hears this.

The solicitor asks for the address of the apartment. Give the address.

The solicitor pauses.

The solicitor says that a letter can be prepared by the end of the week and that the discrepancy in the middle name should be addressed at the civil registry office. The solicitor says to come in on Friday morning. Thank the solicitor. End the call.

Put the mobile in the inside pocket of the coat.

Walk back to the building along the pavement. Past the shops, past the corner with the pharmacy, past the library, along the street with the lime trees, across the crossing, past the bakery.

Unlock the front door of the building and climb the stairs to the third floor. At the top of the third-floor landing, put the key from the right pocket of the coat in the apartment door and turn it. Open the door and go in. Drop the key back into the pocket. Hang the coat on the hook by the door.

Walk through the hallway to the bedroom. Through the bedroom to the living room. Through the living room to the glass door of the balcony. Open the door and step out.

The drying rack stands folded behind the wooden chair by the railing. The wood of the rack is dry. The bars are dry.

Fold the drying rack flat and lean it against the wall.

Back through the living room to the kitchen. Open the cupboard above the coffee machine.

One cup in the cupboard. White, thick at the rim, a chip on the underside of the handle.

Close the cupboard.

Take the list from the inside pocket of the coat at the counter. Count the items. Item 1 through Item 14 are there in their original order. Below Item 14, *15. Sort desk*. Below that, in the same handwriting: *16. the phone*.

Look at the phone on the kitchen wall. The phone is on the wall beside the door to the hall. Black. The cord coiled once around the hook below the handset. The handset on its cradle.

Fold the paper once and then once again and put it back in the inside pocket of the coat.

Put the coat on from the hook. Take the key from the right pocket. Pull the apartment door closed and turn the key in the lock. Drop the key back into the pocket.

Walk down the stairs, past the second-floor landing with its potted plant, and out through the front door of the building.

The street is empty.

Chapter 10 — The Freezer

Unlock the apartment door with the key from the right pocket of the coat and go in. The hallway runs the length of it, doors to left and right. Drop the key back into the pocket. Hang the coat on the hook by the door.

Walk through to the kitchen. The counter is clean. The cups are in the cupboard above the coffee machine. There is one cup in the cupboard.

The glasses are in the cupboard to the left of the plates. Take four down and set them on the counter. Tear a sheet of newspaper from the pile on the kitchen table and lay it flat. Place a glass in the middle of the sheet.

Stop.

The fridge is under the counter to the right of the sink. Under the fridge, a smaller compartment with a separate door: the freezer.

Open the freezer.

The freezer is full.

The top shelf of the freezer holds six plastic containers, each with a masking-tape label on the lid: *Soup, leek and potato, Soup, tomato, Bolognese, Bolognese, Fish stew, Ragout*. The labels are in mother's handwriting.

The second shelf holds four small foil-wrapped packages, each with a strip of masking tape and a date written in biro.

Take the packages out and look at the dates. *Eleventh of February. Eighteenth of February. Fourth of March. Twenty-third of March.*

Look at the date on the mobile taken from the inside pocket of the coat. The date on the mobile is the twentieth of March.

The package dated *Twenty-third of March* is in a hand. The foil is cold. The writing on the masking tape is mother's handwriting.

Put the package back in the freezer with the others.

Close the freezer.

Take a black bin bag from under the sink. Open it on the floor beside the fridge.

Open the freezer again. Take out the containers one at a time and put them in the bag. The containers are frozen solid. The bag fills slowly. Take out the foil packages one at a time and drop them into the bag. Leave the one dated *Twenty-third of March* on the counter.

The bag is heavy at the bottom.

Tie the bag. Carry it down the stairs, past the second-floor landing with its potted plant, out through the front door of the building, to the bins behind the building. Push the bag down into the top of the rubbish bin and close the lid.

Back up the stairs. The third-floor landing. The apartment door, standing open.

Back to the kitchen. The freezer hums. The package dated *Twenty-third of March* is on the counter. Put it back on the top shelf of the empty freezer. Close the freezer door.

Walk to the counter and pick up the glass from the middle of the sheet of newspaper. Place the glass back on the sheet. Bring the corners of the paper up and over and press them around the edge of the glass with the side of a thumb. Pick up the tape from the counter. Pull an inch and cut it on the dispenser's blade. Press the tape across the seam.

Put the wrapped glass in the box at the feet.

Take another sheet of newspaper from the pile on the kitchen table.

The newspaper is today's.

The date at the top of the front page is the twentieth of March. The headline is about a storm that has passed through the north overnight. The photograph below the headline is of a man with an umbrella on a wet street.

Place a glass in the middle of the sheet. Bring the corners up and over.

The phone on the kitchen wall rings.

Put the glass down on the counter. Walk to the phone. Pick up the receiver. Hold it to an ear.

Silence.

Listen to the silence. There is no sound on the line. No breath. No background. Nothing.

Then a dial tone, steady.

Put the receiver back on the cradle.

Walk back to the counter. The glass is on the newspaper. Wrap the glass. Tape the seam. Put the glass in the box.

Take the list from the inside pocket of the coat at the counter. Read it. Item 7, the item about cancelling the phone line, has been rewritten. The item now reads: *answer the phone*. The handwriting of the new text is the same as the handwriting of the rest of the list.

Read the list to the end. Fold the paper once and then once again and put it back in the inside pocket of the coat.

Finish wrapping the remaining two glasses on the counter. Put them in the box. Close the box. Tape the seam. Write KITCHEN on the side with the marker from the counter.

Put the coat on from the hook. Take the key from the right pocket. Pull the apartment door closed and turn the key in the lock. Drop the key back into the pocket.

Walk down the stairs, past the second-floor landing with its potted plant, past the half-flight and the narrow landing and the other half-flight, and out through the front door of the building.

The street is empty.

Chapter 11 — The Solicitor

The solicitor's office is in an older building five streets from the apartment, down a side street with small trees in iron grates on the pavement. The door of the building has a brass plate with three names on it, the solicitor's among them.

Push the door open and climb a narrow flight of stairs to the first floor. A secretary sits at a desk in the reception room. The secretary looks up and nods and presses a button on the desk intercom.

The solicitor comes out from an inner office and shows the way back in. The inner office has bookshelves on two walls, a lamp on the desk, a framed certificate on the wall behind the desk, and two leather chairs on the visitor side. The leather of the visitor chairs is worn smooth at the arms.

Sit in one of the leather chairs. The solicitor sits behind the desk and opens a folder on the blotter.

The solicitor says that a will has been found in the office files after the call on Friday morning. The leather at the arm of the chair is worn smooth. The solicitor says the will is dated six years ago and is the last version on file. The lamp on the desk is lit against the grey of the window. The solicitor says the terms of the will are simple: mother's entire estate, including everything in the apartment, is left to the single named beneficiary.

Wait.

The solicitor reads the beneficiary's name from the first page of the will and looks up.

Confirm.

The solicitor says that a copy of the will can be prepared for the bank. The solicitor says the estate can be transferred to the beneficiary's name once the death certificate discrepancy is resolved at the civil registry office. The solicitor says that the matter of the utility account will be handled by the estate. The solicitor asks whether there are questions.

The middle name on the death certificate is different from the middle name on the birth certificate. The solicitor hears this.

The solicitor says that the civil registry office should be visited on the way back to the apartment, that a corrected death certificate can usually be issued within the hour if the original is a typographical error. The solicitor says that a copy of mother's birth certificate should be brought along.

Thank the solicitor. The solicitor hands across a sealed envelope containing a photocopy of the will and a typed letter of authority for the bank. Put the envelope in the inside pocket of the coat.

Walk out of the inner office, past the secretary at the desk, down the narrow stairs, and out of the building onto the side street.

Walk back along the street. The civil registry office is in the opposite direction. Turn the corner. Walk past the corner with the pharmacy, past the library, along the street with the lime trees, across the crossing, past the bakery.

Unlock the front door of the building and climb the stairs to the third floor. At the top of the third-floor landing, put the key from the right pocket of the coat in the apartment door and turn it. Open the door and go in. Drop the key back into the pocket. Hang the coat on the hook by the door.

Walk into the living room.

The bookshelves run along the long wall.

The bookshelves are empty. The shelves are dusty. At the back of each shelf, the paint is lighter where the spines have stood.

Walk across the living room to the sofa. Put a hand on the back of the sofa. The fabric is not familiar.

The sofa is not mother's sofa. It is a low grey three-seater with a glass-topped coffee table in front of it. The upholstery is still tight on the frame, new. The coffee table has nothing on it. A lamp stands on the floor beside the sofa, not one of mother's lamps. A rug is on the floor, not mother's rug.

Sit down on the floor next to the sofa. The rug under the legs is thin and dark, not mother's rug.

Everything in the apartment belongs to the person sitting on the floor beside the glass-topped coffee table.

Stay on the floor for a while. Do not open any boxes. Do not wrap anything.

Through the open door of the living room the hallway runs the length of the apartment. The kitchen is at the end of the hall on the right. The coat is on the hook by the front door.

The list is in the inside pocket of the coat on the hook. Do not consult the list.

Stand up from the floor. Walk through the hallway to the front door. Put the coat on. Take the key from the right pocket of the coat. Pull the apartment door closed and turn the key in the lock. Drop the key back into the pocket.

Walk down the stairs, past the second-floor landing with its potted plant, past the half-flight and the narrow landing and the other half-flight, and out through the front door of the building.

The street is empty.

Chapter 12 — The Inscription

Unlock the apartment door with the key from the right pocket of the coat and go in. The hallway runs the length of it, doors to left and right. Drop the key back into the pocket. Hang the coat on the hook by the door.

Walk through to the kitchen. The counter is clean. The cups are in the cupboard above the coffee machine. The phone is on the wall beside the door to the hall. The elm is at the window. The rectangle of afternoon light on the counter reaches almost to the sink.

Take the list out of the inside pocket of the coat and read it at the kitchen counter. Item 5 is above Item 4. Item 9 is below Item 11. Item 7 reads in smaller letters: *answer the phone*. Near the bottom, in the same handwriting, another entry: *the summer with the door*. Read the list to the end. Fold the paper once and then once again and put it back in the inside pocket of the coat.

Walk through the hallway to the living room.

The bookshelves run along the long wall, full.

Get the tape gun from the table by the front door. A stack of flat boxes leans against the wall in the hall. Take four boxes and carry them to the living room. Assemble two of them on the floor in front of the bookshelves. Leave the other two flat beside the shelves for later.

Take the books down four at a time. Wrap them in sheets of newspaper from the pile beside the boxes. Put them in the open box in the order they come off the shelf. Do not read the titles. The books are heavy and the weight fills the box quickly. At twelve books, fold the newspaper flaps over the top, close the box, run a strip of tape along the seam, and write LIVING ROOM on the side with the marker from the floor.

Assemble the next box.

Start on the second shelf. Take the books down four at a time. Wrap them. Do not read the titles.

Finish the second shelf. Fold the newspaper over the top of the second box. Close and tape. Label.

Start on the third shelf.

On the third shelf, a hand stops on a hardback.

Take it down. The cover is dark cloth, no dust jacket. The spine is worn and slightly bowed where the pages have been held open more than once. Turn it over and read the spine. The title is not familiar and not unfamiliar. Open the book at the front. The spine falls open at the flyleaf.

On the page before the title page is an inscription. The handwriting is the handwriting of the list in the inside pocket of the coat.

I meant to come in the summer. I did not come. I know you waited. I could not sit across from you at the table. I did not know how to then either. I am writing this on the page because I cannot say it. I am sorry I could not say it. I should have come.

Close the book. Wrap it in a sheet of newspaper and put it in the box with the others. Run a strip of tape across the seam of the sheet.

Take down the next four books.

Finish the third shelf. Move to the fourth shelf. Wrap and box. The fourth box fills and is closed and labelled LIVING ROOM.

Assemble the next box.

Finish the long wall of the bookshelves. The short wall by the window. The top shelves, reached by the chair from the kitchen table. The bottom shelves, kneeling on the rug.

At the end of the afternoon, six boxes stand in two stacks by the front door. The shelves are empty. At the back of each shelf, the paint is lighter where the spines have stood.

Take a glass from the cupboard above the coffee machine and fill it at the kitchen tap. Drink the water at the counter. The elm is at the window. The light from the window falls across the counter in a rectangle that reaches almost to the sink. The rectangle moves as the clouds shift and then holds. The elm's higher branches make small shadows across the rectangle.

Finish the water. Rinse the glass and put it back in the cupboard above the coffee machine.

Carry the first two boxes to the stairwell and start down.

The third-floor landing. The stairs down. The second-floor landing with the potted plant. The stairs below the second-floor landing. Then more stairs.

A half-flight between the second-floor landing and the ground floor. The half-flight ends at a narrow landing painted the same brown as the rest of the stairwell, the paint worn in a small patch at the middle where feet have stood and turned for years. From the narrow landing, another half-flight continues down to the ground floor.

Walk down the half-flight. Stand on the narrow landing with the boxes in hand. Walk down the other half-flight. The ground floor.

Out through the front door of the building. The car is at the kerb. Open the boot and put the two boxes in and close the boot.

Climb the stairs back up. The ground floor. The half-flight. The narrow landing. The half-flight. The second-floor landing with the potted plant. The third-floor landing. The door of the apartment, standing open.

Carry the next two boxes down. The half-flight and the narrow landing are still there. Put the boxes in the boot beside the first two.

Return for the last two. Carry them down the stairs. Past the potted plant. Past the half-flight and the narrow landing and the other half-flight. Out through the front door of the building. Put the boxes in the boot. Close the boot.

Back up the stairs. The third-floor landing. The apartment door, standing open.

Inside, one more thing. Take the list from the inside pocket of the coat and read it again at the kitchen counter. The entry that says *the summer with the door* has become a short paragraph under a line drawn across the page. Some of the words are legible and some are not. Fold the paper once and then once again and put it back in the inside pocket of the coat.

Put the coat on from the hook by the door. Take the key from the right pocket of the coat. Pull the apartment door closed and turn the key in the lock. Drop the key back into the pocket.

Walk down the stairs. The second-floor landing with its potted plant. The stairs below. The half-flight. The narrow landing. The half-flight. The ground floor. Out through the front door of the building.

The street is empty.

Chapter 13 — The Phone Call

Unlock the apartment door with the key from the right pocket of the coat and go in. The hallway runs the length of it, doors to left and right. Drop the key back into the pocket. Hang the coat on the hook by the door.

Walk through to the kitchen. The counter is clean. The cups are in the cupboard above the coffee machine.

Open the kitchen drawer under the counter. The drawer has the scissors, the ball of kitchen twine, the roll of masking tape, the small notebook, the fold-down reading glasses, the two pens, the box of matches, the packet of seeds, and one other piece of paper.

The piece of paper is a phone bill from the telephone company, folded once, with the account number printed at the top and the monthly charges listed below.

Take the phone bill out and put it on the counter. Close the drawer.

Take the mobile from the inside pocket of the coat and dial the number of the telephone company from the top of the phone bill. The line rings twice and a recorded voice asks for the account number. Press the numbers on the mobile. The recorded voice holds, and then an operator picks up.

The operator is a woman with a kind voice. The operator asks how to help.

The question is about the line at the apartment. The operator asks for the account number. The account number is on the bill. The operator hears the digits and types them in.

The operator says the line has been disconnected for four months.

Stop. The phone on the kitchen wall has rung. The receiver has been picked up and there has been silence and then a dial tone. The phone has rung more than once. The operator hears all of this.

The phone rings again. The receiver is picked up again.

The operator says the line has been disconnected for four months and asks whether there is another account number. Give the account number again. The operator types. The operator reads the account number back. Confirm.

The operator says that under the account number the line has been disconnected for four months, that no signal has been routed to this line since the disconnection, and that the final bill is the one in hand. The operator asks whether there is anything else.

The answer is no.

Thank the operator. End the call. Put the mobile on the counter.

Walk to the phone on the kitchen wall.

Pick up the receiver. Hold it to an ear. No dial tone. No background hum.

Put the receiver back on the cradle.

Pick it up again. Nothing. Put it back.

Sit down at the small round table under the kitchen window. The elm is at the window. The light from the window falls across the counter in a rectangle that reaches almost to the sink. The rectangle moves as the clouds shift and then holds.

A long time.

Stand up from the chair. Walk to the front door. Put the coat on from the hook. Take the key from the right pocket. Pull the apartment door closed and turn the key in the lock. Drop the key back into the pocket.

Walk down the stairs, past the second-floor landing with its potted plant, past the half-flight and the narrow landing and the other half-flight, and out through the front door of the building.

The street is empty.

Walk three blocks home. Unlock the door and go in. Hang the coat on the hook in the hall.

Make something from the fridge: bread, cheese, a tomato, a glass of water. Eat at the kitchen counter. Stand at the counter while eating. The evening light is in the kitchen window.

Finish eating. Wash the plate and the glass and put them in the rack.

Take the list from the inside pocket of the coat at the kitchen counter. Read it at the counter.

The items are not in order. Some items are crossed off. Some are not. Item 7 still says *answer the phone*. Item 16 says *the phone*. The paragraph at the top has grown longer. Below the paragraph, a word at the end of a line: *forgive*. The handwriting of the word is not clearly the handwriting of the list.

Read the word once.

Fold the paper once and then once again and put it on the kitchen counter.

Go to the bedroom. Undress. Bed.

Dark.

Chapter 14 — The Rooms

Unlock the apartment door with the key from the right pocket of the coat and go in. The hallway runs the length of it, doors to left and right. Drop the key back into the pocket. Hang the coat on the hook by the door.

Take the list from the inside pocket of the coat and read it in the hallway. A paragraph runs across the top of the page, long, without numbers. Some words are legible and some are not. *answer the phone. forgive. the summer with the door.* Below the paragraph, the numbered list has become another paragraph, and under that, a third. Fold the paper once and then once again and put it back in the inside pocket of the coat.

Walk through the apartment.

The kitchen is on the right at the end of the hall. The window above the sink faces the elm. The counter is clean. The cups are in the cupboard above the coffee machine. The phone is on the wall beside the door to the hall. On the kitchen counter, beside the coffee machine, stands a cup of coffee, half-full.

Continue down the hallway.

From the hallway, left into the bedroom. The wardrobe stands against the back wall, closed. The bed is made. The dressing table is by the window, the small bottle of perfume on it. Through the bedroom, at the back corner, a doorway leads into another room.

Walk through the doorway.

Inside, a piano.

The piano is an upright in dark wood. The lid is closed, the stool tucked in under the keys. The keys are yellowed and uneven, some worn whiter where fingers have pressed them for years. Against the far wall stands a music stand, empty. The room is small, the ceiling higher than the bedroom's, the walls painted the same off-white. A small window in the back wall looks onto a courtyard.

Walk across the piano room. At the far corner is another doorway.

Through the piano-room doorway into a small study. By the wall under the window stands a chair, and beside the chair a side table with a reading lamp on it. On the side table next to the lamp sits a cup of coffee, half-full, the coffee the colour of old coffee with a thin skin across the surface. On the chair, a book lies open, face down. The cup is white, thick at the rim, a chip on the underside of the handle. The window of the study looks onto the same courtyard. The courtyard has a tree in it, and a row of bins against a brick wall, and a patch of gravel.

Put a hand on the cup. The coffee is warm.

Lift the book from the chair and turn it over to read the spine. The title is not familiar and not unfamiliar. Put the book back on the chair, open, face down.

Turn around.

The doorway back to the piano room is there. Walk through the doorway. The piano room is not there. The doorway opens into the bedroom. The wardrobe stands against the back wall, closed. The bed is made. The dressing table is by the window.

Walk through the bedroom into the hallway. The hallway runs the length of the apartment, doors to left and right. Walk along the hallway to the living room, then back along the other side of the hallway to the kitchen.

On the kitchen counter, beside the coffee machine, stands a cup of coffee, half-full. Put a hand on it. The coffee is warm.

Put the cup down. Walk to the cupboard above the coffee machine and open it.

The cups are in the cupboard. Take one down. The cup is white, thick at the rim, a chip on the underside of the handle. Put it on the counter next to the half-full cup. The two cups are the same cup.

Back to the work.

The boxes are stacked beside the counter. The newspaper is in a pile on the small round table by the window. The plates are in the cupboard above the coffee machine, beside the cups.

Take a plate down from the cupboard. Tear a sheet of newspaper from the pile and lay it flat on the counter.

Wrap a plate and the plate is a cup and wrap the cup and the cup is a plate and put the plate in the box. Take a cup from the cupboard above the coffee machine, wrap it in a sheet of newspaper, and put it in the box. Take another plate down. Wrap it. Put it in the box. The plate is a shirt. Fold and stack it in the box.

Take another cup from the cupboard. Wrap the cup and put it in the box.

Close the box. Run a strip of tape along the seam. Label the side with the marker from the counter.

The word on the side of the box is **WARDROBE**.

Assemble the next box. Take the photographs from the shoebox on the living room shelf and carry them back to the kitchen. Put the photographs in the box. Close the box and run a strip of tape along the seam. Label the side.

Two boxes by the counter.

Stand at the counter. The elm is at the window. The light from the window falls across the counter in a rectangle that reaches almost to the sink. The rectangle moves as the clouds shift and then holds. The cup of coffee beside the coffee machine is still warm.

Pick up the warm cup and take it to the sink. Pour the coffee down the drain. Rinse the cup and put it back in the cupboard above the coffee machine, next to the others.

Take another plate from the cupboard.

Wrap it in newspaper. The plate is a plate. Put it in the box labelled **KITCHEN**, on top of the photographs.

Take another plate from the cupboard. Wrap it. Put it in the box.

Take another plate down. Wrap it. Put it in the box.

At some point, stop.

Take the list from the inside pocket of the coat and read it at the counter. The paragraph at the top has grown longer. A word near the middle of the paragraph, legible for a moment and then illegible again: *Marianne*. Below the paragraph, another paragraph has appeared, in the same handwriting but looser. Fold the paper once and then once again and put it back in the inside pocket of the coat.

Put the coat on from the hook by the door. Take the key from the right pocket of the coat. Pull the apartment door closed and turn the key in the lock. Drop the key back into the pocket.

Walk down the stairs. The second-floor landing with its potted plant. The stairs below. The half-flight and the narrow landing and the other half-flight. The ground floor. Out through the front door of the building.

The street is empty.

Chapter 15 — The Boxes

Unlock the apartment door with the key from the right pocket of the coat and go in. The hallway runs the length of it, doors to left and right. Drop the key back into the pocket. Hang the coat on the hook by the door.

Walk through to the kitchen. The coffee machine is on the counter, the cupboard above it, the small round table under the window. Against the wall leans a stack of flat boxes with one already pulled from the top and half-assembled on the floor beside it. The newspaper is on the chair.

Assemble two boxes on the floor.

Take a sheet of newspaper from the pile. Lay it flat on the counter. Take a glass from the cupboard above the coffee machine and place it in the middle of the sheet. Bring the corners of the paper up and over and press them around the edge of the glass with the side of a thumb. Pick up the tape from the counter, pull an inch, cut it on the dispenser's blade, and press the tape across the seam.

Put the wrapped glass in the box at the feet.

Put a book in the box at the feet.

Take another sheet of newspaper. Fold a shirt and stack the shirt in the box. Take a plate from the cupboard. Wrap the plate. Put the plate in the box.

Take another book from somewhere and put it in the box.

Close the box. Run a strip of tape along the seam. Label the side with the marker from the counter. The word on the side of the box is KITCHEN.

Assemble the next box.

Take the shoebox of photographs from the living room shelf and carry it to the counter. Take the photographs out one at a time and put them in the box. The box fills with photographs. Close the box. Run a strip of tape along the seam. Label the side. The word on the side of the box is BEDROOM.

Two boxes by the counter.

Put the coat on from the hook. Carry the two boxes to the car parked at the kerb. Down the stairs, past the second-floor landing with its potted plant, past the half-flight and the narrow landing and the other half-flight, out through the front door of the building. Put the boxes in the boot and close the boot.

Drive to the charity shop.

The charity shop is in a building on the main road six streets from the apartment, in the direction of the centre of the city. Park at the kerb outside the building. Open the boot and carry the two boxes to the door of the charity shop.

The charity shop is in the building of the library. Racks of second-hand clothes hang in the library windows.

Push the door open and carry the boxes in.

A volunteer behind the counter is older, a woman with short grey hair, wearing a name badge. The volunteer nods thanks and points to a table at the back for donations. Carry the boxes to the table. Put them down on the table. Go back to the car.

Drive back to the building. Park at the kerb.

Unlock the front door of the building and climb the stairs to the third floor. At the top of the third-floor landing, put the key from the right pocket of the coat in the apartment door and turn it. Open the door and go in. Drop the key back into the pocket. Hang the coat on the hook by the door.

Walk through the hallway.

At the end of the hallway on the left, past the bedroom door, is another door that has not been opened. The door has not been here before.

Open the door.

Inside is a small room with a single window. Against the wall stands a small bed, made up with a blue cover. A wooden desk sits on the other side of the room with a shelf above it. The shelf holds a few books and a model of a ship. The ship is three-masted, the rigging made of thread, one of the sails torn.

Stand at the door of the room.

On the wall above the desk are three sheets of paper, stuck to the wall with tape at the corners. Crayon drawings.

The first drawing is of a house: a square house with a pitched roof, a door in the middle, two windows above the door, a chimney with smoke coming out, a tree beside the house, a sun with rays in the top corner, and a line of grass at the bottom.

The second drawing is of a tall person and a small person standing side by side in front of the same house. The tall person has long hair and is wearing a dress. The small person is wearing a striped shirt. They are holding hands.

The third drawing is of a garden with long grass and three fruit trees, and behind the garden a house with a red door, and at the door a figure, too small to see clearly.

Walk to the desk. Reach up to the wall and peel the tape off the corners of the first drawing. The tape is dry and comes away in one piece. Take the drawing down carefully so the paper does not tear. The paper is thin and slightly foxed at the edges. Peel the tape off the second drawing. Take it down. Peel the tape off the third. Take it down.

Roll the three drawings together into a loose tube. The paper is stiff at the edges and soft in the middle.

Walk back through the hallway to the front door. Put the rolled drawings into the inside pocket of the coat, folding them if necessary to fit.

Put the coat on.

Stand at the door for a moment. Take the folded paper out of the inside pocket of the coat and unfold it.

The paper is the grocery list in mother's handwriting. *Milk, bread, fish, oranges.*

Fold the paper once and then once again and put it back in the inside pocket of the coat with the rolled drawings.

Take the key from the right pocket of the coat. Pull the apartment door closed and turn the key in the lock. Drop the key back into the pocket.

Walk down the stairs, past the second-floor landing with its potted plant, past the half-flight and the narrow landing and the other half-flight, and out through the front door of the building.

The street is empty.

Chapter 16 — The Photograph

Morning.

The kitchen of the apartment that is not mother's apartment. The counter is clean. The coffee machine sits on the counter to the left of the sink. The cups are in the cupboard above the coffee machine.

The coat is on the hook in the hall.

Fill the kettle from the tap and put it on the hob. Take a cup down from the cupboard. The cup is not mother's cup. Spoon coffee into the cup. Pour the water and stir.

Drink the coffee at the window.

The street below is quiet. The bakery on the corner is open. A woman passes with a paper bag. The opposite building has five windows on the second floor of its grey facade.

Finish the coffee. Rinse the cup under the tap and put it back in the cupboard.

Walk into the hall. The coat is on the hook. Take the photograph from the inside pocket of the coat.

The photograph is mother and a child on a low wall in a garden with long grass. Carry the photograph to the small table by the window of the living room and put it down on the table.

Two people in the photograph.

Sit down in the chair by the window across from the table. Look at the photograph from the chair.

Three people in the photograph. A woman stands behind mother and the child, in the grass, her face out of focus.

Stand up. Walk to the table and pick up the photograph. Hold it close.

Two people in the photograph. Mother on the low wall with her arm around the child's shoulders. The garden with long grass. The sun on mother's face.

Put the photograph down on the table again. Walk to the window and look out. The bakery on the corner is open. A man with a dog crosses the street. The street is wet from a rain that has stopped. The elm in the small park at the end of the street is moving in a wind.

Turn around.

Walk back to the table. The photograph is on the table. Pick it up.

Mother, the child, the woman behind. Three people. The woman is out of focus and the child is in focus and mother is in focus.

Put the photograph on the table and walk to the kitchen. Drink a glass of water at the sink. Wash a bowl from the morning. Walk back through the hall to the living room.

The photograph is on the small table by the window. From the doorway of the living room, the photograph shows one woman in a kitchen. She is not smiling. Her face is open and patient and she is looking at whoever

holds the camera. The kitchen is not mother's kitchen. The kitchen is somewhere else, somewhere that cannot be placed. The woman is not mother and not the woman in the grass and not the child grown up.

Walk across the room to the table.

From across the room, the photograph is one woman in a kitchen.

Pick up the photograph.

Mother and the child in the garden with long grass. Two people.

Put the photograph in the inside pocket of the coat on the hook by the front door.

Walk back to the living room and stand at the window for a long time.

The afternoon passes. The light on the opposite building moves across the grey facade as a cloud moves. The cars pass.

Eat something from the fridge in the middle of the day: bread and cheese at the counter. Wash the plate and put it in the rack.

In the middle of the afternoon, walk back to the hall and take a blank sheet of paper from the drawer of the hall table. Carry the paper to the living room and put it on the small table by the window.

Take a pen from a jar on the bookshelf.

Sit in the chair across from the table with the pen in one hand and the blank paper on the table.

After a long time, put the pen down on the paper on the table.

Through the evening, stand at the window and then sit in the chair and then stand at the window. A neighbouring flat has voices in it, faint through the wall. The voices are of two people talking quietly in a language that could be the local language or another language, too muffled to tell.

Listen for a while.

Eat something in the evening. Wash the dishes.

Turn off the lamps in the living room. The hallway lamp. The kitchen light.

Go to the bedroom. Undress. Bed.

Dark.

Chapter 17 — Continue

Open the front door with the key and go in.

The apartment is quiet. The hallway runs the length of it, doors to left and right. The smell is the smell of an apartment that has not been opened for a few days. Underneath is the smell of old wool and soap.

Walk through the rooms.

The kitchen is on the right at the end of the hall. The window above the sink faces the elm. The counter is clean. The coffee machine sits on the counter to the left of the sink, the cups in the cupboard above it, a jar of pens beside the sink. The phone is on the wall beside the door to the hall. Under the window opposite the counter stands a small round table with two chairs. The surface of the table is marked with two pale rings where hot pans have been set down and left for years.

The living room is at the far end of the hall, past the kitchen door. The bookshelves run along the long wall, full. Against the window wall sits a sofa with a coffee table in front of it, a lamp beside the sofa. The rug on the floor is frayed at the edges and has lost its colour at the centre where the path from the sofa to the door has worn a track. The television is not on.

The bedroom is off the hallway to the left. The wardrobe stands against the back wall, closed. The bed is made: a white cover, two pillows. Beside the bed stands a bedside table with a lamp and a book on it. The book is a paperback, the spine creased, a slip of paper at about a third of the way through. The slip is a torn corner of newspaper. The dressing table is by the window, a small bottle of perfume on it.

The second room is next to the bedroom. Boxes are stacked along one wall, a folded camp bed in the corner, three cardboard boxes on the floor, taped shut, unlabelled. A window at the back looks onto the inner courtyard.

The bathroom is off the hallway on the right. White tiles cover the walls to half-height. Above the sink hangs a mirror beside a small window. The silvering of the mirror is spotted at the edges and clouded where the hot water has risen against it for years. On the shelf below stand a toothbrush in a glass and a bar of soap dried on a dish.

The balcony is off the living room through a glass door. Two dead plants in terracotta pots stand by the wall. A wooden chair is by the railing. The chair is old and weathered, the slats of the seat split where the wood has dried over the years.

Walk back through the hallway to the kitchen.

Fill the kettle from the tap and put it on the hob. Turn the dial for the front burner and the flame catches. Take a cup down from the cupboard above the coffee machine without looking. The cup is one of mother's, white, thick at the rim, a chip on the underside of the handle. Take the jar of coffee from the cupboard beside the fridge and spoon two spoonfuls into the cup. The kettle ticks and then clicks off. Turn off the flame. Pour the water and stir with a spoon from the drawer under the counter.

Drink the coffee at the counter.

The elm is at the window. The light from the window falls across the counter in a rectangle that reaches almost to the sink. A cyclist passes on the street below, then a woman with a shopping bag the other way,

then a man with a dog. The rectangle of light moves as the clouds shift and then holds. The elm's higher branches make small shadows across the rectangle. The cup is warm in a hand.

Finish the coffee. Rinse the cup under the tap and put it back in the cupboard above the coffee machine.

Take the grocery list from the inside pocket of the coat and put it on the counter. Smooth it open with a thumb. Take the key from the right pocket of the coat and put it beside the paper. Take the photograph of mother and the child from the inside pocket of the coat and put it beside the key.

The paper, the key, and the photograph lie in a row on the counter between the coffee machine and the sink.

Walk to the front door. Open it. Do not look back. Do not lock it. Walk down the stairs, past the second-floor landing with its potted plant, and out through the front door of the building.

The street is empty.

The bakery on the corner is open. Walk past the bakery to the crossing. The light at the crossing is red. Wait. A car passes. The light changes. Cross the street.

Walk three blocks home. Unlock the door and go in. Hang the coat on the hook in the hall.

Sit down in the chair by the window.

See the light through the window move across the floor.